EPP divided on expansion of aviation ETS, Parliament rapporteur says

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EPP divided on expansion of aviation ETS, Parliament rapporteur says
By Tommaso Lecca · Oct 28, 2026, 1:56 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — The center-right European People's Party is divided on whether to extend the Emissions Trading System to flights departing the EU for destinations in the Middle East and North Africa, European Parliament rapporteur for the ETS revision Peter Liese said Wednesday.

The European Commission proposed in July to extend the geographical scope of the aviation ETS, currently limited to flights within the European Economic Area, to routes departing from EU airports and landing at destinations within 5,000 kilometers of Frankfurt Airport, which serves as a reference point because of its central location in Europe.

Liese is currently negotiating a compromise draft with other parliamentary groups to be voted on in the plenary in December.

"In the EPP, we have different positions," Liese, himself an EPP lawmaker, said at a press briefing Wednesday. "Our TRAN colleagues rather support the current scope," he said, referring to EPP members of the Parliement's Transport Committee. But "others support the Commission proposal," he added.

He said the Socialists and Democrats, centrist Renew Europe, the Greens and the Left support the Commission's proposal to extend, while "there is a lot of opposition" from the European Conservatives and Reformists and far-right groups Europe of Sovereign Nations and Patriots for Europe.

Liese confirmed his personal support for the Commission proposal "because we have [a] distortion of competition, for example, for the European hubs," he said, noting that the current ETS rules encourage European travelers to make a stopover at non-EU airports when flying to Asia. That's because a journey from the EU to Asia via another EU airport is subject to ETS carbon pricing on its first leg, while connecting through a non-EU hub allows airlines and passengers to avoid those costs.

Liese said he's working on a compromise that would increase the share of ETS revenues being "recycled to the innovation in the aviation sector."

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